

She apologized three times before asking a single question.

Not because she did anything wrong – she didn't.
She just thought speaking was already too much.

Every word she says arrives dressed in hesitation.
Like it's been rehearsed, rejected, reworded, and still came out broken.

She looks at me like I might give her permission to exist.

And sometimes I do.
But not all the time.
She shouldn't get used to it.

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